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Trail of Bytes

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Mention crime, and we think of robberies, murders and detectives examining the scene, interrogating witnesses and finally nailing the guilty.

There is, however, another kind of crime, where traditional methods of criminal investigation fall flat on its face. Instances like hack attacks, cyber fraud, phishing, identity and data theft, all account as cyber crime. Even though it may appear that the effects of digital crime are not life threatening, they have the potential to disrupt life, as well as tamper with property. Just imagine, a situation if Indian Railway's ticket reservation system goes down for even a day? In fact, a survey in UK concluded that people were more scared of their bank accounts being hacked or credit card details stolen over the Internet, than they were of muggings and robberies.

We could go on and on about different scenarios, but the point is, digital crime occurs. While better information security would certainly act as a deterrent, crime can never be totally eradicated. So, the next best thing to do, is to find out the culprit. When the crime committed is related to the Internet and computers, then cyber forensic expert enter the scene, and try to sniff out the clues, and trace the byte-trail that can help in catching the perpetrators.

On The Job

Digital forensics, of which cyber forensics is one facet, is a vast discipline, which encompasses several other fields. A digital forensic expert is supposed to be adept in network security, because most cyber crimes take place over networks. He / she needs to be good at encryption and data recovery too, because passwords and data are always inevitably involved in theft of information. Awareness of cyber laws are also important, as most of these cases can go to

court where the forensic expert would be called either as a witness for prosecution or defence. Again, cyber forensics does not necessarily mean that its practitioners would have to deal with computers and servers all the time. Depending on cases, mobile phones, pen drives and in some cases, even personal media players have come under the scanner of the e-sleuths.

Cyber Crime And Legal Aspects

Before we proceed deeper into the subject, there is an urgent need to know what cyber crime actually is. The United Nations defines cyber crime as illegal electronic operations that target the security of computer systems and data processed by them, or illegal behaviour that uses computers and networks.

In India, the primary statute is the IT Act 2000, although some sections of other laws like the Indian Penal Code can be applied to digital crime. We are not

While instances of crime in the cyber space shoot up, demand for forensic experts also increase. We explore the options

